Committee: United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC)

Topic: Addressing Gender-Based Violence and Discrimination

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Table of Contents

1. Introduction

2. Definition of Essential Terms

3. General Context

4. Key Parties Involved and Their Perspectives

5. Questions to Consider

6. Suggested Resources

7. Conclusion

8. Bibliography

1. Introduction

Sexism is one of the most influential and widespread issues around the world, and one of the oldest. It can affect many areas of life, including education, healthcare, employment, and political participation. Although progress has been made in many countries, gender based discrimination remains a major global issue.

Gender-based discrimination can also be seen in laws and legal systems. One example is child marriage, where individuals under the age of 18 are allowed to marry, often with parental or judicial consent. Child marriage can limit access to education, increase health risks, and reduce future employment opportunities. In many cases, it can also be considered a form of gender based violence.

When it comes to violence, almost 1 in 3women in the world have experienced physical or sexual violence from either an intimate partner or another person, and the aftereffects can be depression, unplanned pregnancies, anxiety disorders, and more life-altering struggles, some of them being fatal. Femicides are another form of gender-based violence, where around 137 women and girls are killed every day by intimate partners or family members.

Because of its widespread impact on individuals and societies, addressing gender based violence and discrimination is an important priority for the United Nations and the general international community.

2. Definition of Essential Terms

a) **Femicide**: The intentional killing of women or girls because of their gender. It can be connected to domestic violence, harmful gender norms, or other forms of gender based violence.

b) **Child Marriage**: Any formal marriage or informal union where at least one person is under the age of 18. Child marriage can prevent children from continuing their education and can increase their risk of violence and exploitation.

c) **Gender-Based Violence:** Violence directed at a person because of their gender or violence that affects one gender disproportionately. It can include physical, sexual, psychological, or other forms of violence.

d) **Gender Discrimination:** Treating someone unfairly or denying them opportunities because of their gender. It can occur in areas such as education, employment, healthcare, and access to rights.

e) **Intersectionality**: The idea that different parts of a person's identity, such as gender, race, disability, or economic background, can overlap and affect how they experience discrimination or violence.

3. General Context

Historically, women and girls have faced discrimination in many areas of life, including education, employment, marriage, and legal rights. In many societies, men had greater power in families and communities, while women had fewer opportunities and protections. Practices such as child marriage and violence against women were also more widely accepted. Even though many countries have made progress toward gender equality, these issues still exist today.

Over time, international efforts to protect women's rights and promote gender equality became stronger. The UN adopted CEDAW, the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women, which calls on countries to eliminate discrimination against women. Gender equality is also included in Sustainable Development Goal 5, which aims to achieve gender equality and empower women and girls.

Despite progress, gender-based violence and discrimination remain a very serious global issue. Many cases of domestic violence and sexual violence are never reported because victims may fear not being believed, blamed, or protected. In some countries, police and legal systems may also lack the training and/or resources needed to respond effectively. This can make it difficult for victims to receive justice as well as protection.

Honor-based violence is another form of gender-based violence. It can include forced marriage, restrictions on clothing and behaviour, and violence against people who are seen as bringing shame to their family. Such practices can limit a person's freedom, consent, and right to make decisions about their own life.

Sexual assault is also a form of gender-based violence. It can be connected to unequal power between people and can have serious physical and emotional effects on victims. Preventing sexual violence requires not just education on consent and stronger protections for victims, but also effective laws and reporting systems.

4. Key Parties Involved and their Perspectives

a) Major States

Sweden

Supports gender equality as a human rights issue and focuses on equal pay, education, and protection from violence. Sweden was the first country to adopt a Feminist Foreign Policy, based on representation, rights, and resources.

India

India has introduced laws and programs such as the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act (2005) and the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act (2006). However, around 23% of young women in India were married before the age of 18, showing that child marriage remains a major issue.

Nigeria

Nigeria introduced the Violence Against Persons (Prohibition) Act in 2015, which addresses issues such as domestic violence and forced marriage. However, Nigeria has more than 23 million women and girls who were married as children, and enforcement of protections remains a large challenge.

Rwanda

Rwanda has one of the world's highest levels of women's political representation, with women holding 63.7% of seats in its Chamber of Deputies in 2024. However, gender based violence and economic inequality remain issues despite this progress.

United States of America

The US has protections such as the Violence Against Women Act (VAWA) and Title IX. However, reproductive rights remain highly debated. The 2022 *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* decision overturned the federal constitutional right to abortion, leaving individual states to decide their own policies.

Afghanistan

Since the Taliban returned to power in 2021, women and girls have faced severe restrictions on education, employment, movement, and public life. Afghanistan is currently the only country where girls and women are banned from secondary and higher education under the de facto authorities.

b) International Branches/Organizations

UN Women

Aims to promote gender equality and prevent gender-based violence through research, programs, and support for governments. However, it cannot directly force countries to change their laws, so its work depends on government cooperation.

World Health Organization (WHO)

The WHO treats gender-based violence as a public health issue. It focuses on its physical and mental health effects and supports prevention, healthcare, and services for survivors.

UNICEF

UNICEF focuses on protecting children from violence, discrimination, and harmful practices such as child marriage. It also supports education and child protection programs, particularly in countries where these issues remain widespread.

Global Protection Cluster

The GPC coordinates protection efforts during humanitarian crises. Its Gender-Based Violence Area of Responsibility, led by UNFPA, focuses on preventing and responding to gender-based violence during conflicts and disasters.

c) Regional Blocs

European Union (EU)

Currently focuses on tackling gender-based cyberviolence, such as sharing private and intimate photos of women, cyberstalking, and doxing. Other priorities include women's health and gender gaps in employment. Stresses that gender-based discrimination and violence are fundamental human rights violations and structural symptoms of historical gender inequality.

African Union (AU)

The African Union promotes women's rights through frameworks such as the Maputo Protocol, which addresses women's rights, health, marriage, and protection from violence. However, implementation differs between countries, and child marriage and gender based violence remain major issues in parts of Africa.

5. Questions to Consider

1. What are the main causes of gender-based violence and discrimination, and how can they be addressed?

2. How can governments better protect people from gender-based violence and discrimination?

3. What laws and policies can be introduced or improved to prevent gender-based violence and discrimination?

4. How can schools and communities help prevent gender-based violence and promote gender equality?

5. How can governments better support and protect survivors of gender-based violence?

6. How can countries and international organizations work together to address gender-based violence and discrimination?

7. How can children be protected from gender-based violence and harmful practices such as child marriage?

6. Suggested Research Resources

a) Gender Equality Index (EIGE)

https://eige.europa.eu/gender-equality-index/2025

This source includes the rating for progress and development of gender equality measured on a scale of 1 to 100, 1 meaning no gender equality, 100 meaning total gender equality. This only applies to the EU, and it's 27 countries.

b) Resolution 1325 (2000)

https://www.securitycouncilreport.org/atf/cf/%7B65BFCF9B-6D27-4E9C-8CD3-CF6E4FF96FF9%7D/WPS%20SRES1325%20.pdf

This source focuses on the Women, Peace and Security (WPS) agenda and addresses the protection and participation of women during conflict and peacebuilding.

c) Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW)

https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/cedaw.pdf

Adopted in 1979, CEDAW is one of the most important international agreements addressing discrimination against women.

d) United Nations Reports and Resolutions

https://www.un.org/womenwatch/daw/vaw/reports.htm

This source shows multiple reports, resolutions, and resources about gender based violence and discrimination against women.

7. Conclusion

Gender-based violence and discrimination continue to affect people around the world. Addressing these issues requires prevention, stronger laws, support for survivors, and equal access to education and opportunities. Governments, international organizations, and communities all have a role to play in creating safer and more equal societies.

This committee should focus on practical solutions that can prevent gender-based violence and discrimination, protect those at risk, support survivors, and improve cooperation between countries and organizations. Delegates are encouraged to create a resolution that addresses gender-based violence and discrimination, including ways to prevent it, respond to incidents, and to provide the necessary resources and support for those affected.

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